

Q What should I eat to optimize recovery after the birth?

The energy demands of new motherhood are immense, and yet at the same time you are still recovering from the birth and likely to feel sleep deprived and time poor. You may not have time to cook a complex meal, but you can eat well.

Making sure you get enough proper nutrition is immensely important. Your body is recovering from the tremendous physical exertion of the birth, and you are undoubtedly exhausted. You may even find you are anemic if you lost blood during the birth, or if you've had more than one baby. Although diet can't compensate for any sleep deprivation, eating enough nutrient-rich snacks and meals will help to quicken your physical recovery, help to combat any nutritional issues such as constipation, provide your body with fuel to give you the stamina to care for your baby, and help you feel better.

Healthy habits

If you established good shopping and eating habits in pregnancy, you should already be in the right mindset for continuing to eat a balanced diet. If not, this is a key time to avoid "empty calories" such as junk food and sugary snacks. They supply very little nutritional value and provide only a temporary boost of energy, leaving you feeling more tired than before. Include a wide variety of colorful fresh fruit and vegetables, whole grains, lean protein, and dairy products in your diet (see p.50). If you

are lacking iron, your doctor may recommend that you restore your iron levels through both diet and supplement, so choose iron-rich sources such as lean red meat, spinach, and chickpeas. If you have constipation, eat lots of fruit and vegetables, drink more water, and eat plenty of fiber: choose oats, whole-grain breads, brown rice, bran, and other high-fiber cereals. If you had a cesarean section or surgery after the birth, increase your intake of Vitamin C, which contributes to incision healing, and protein, helping your body to repair itself.

All this may sound good in theory, but in practice you might have little time to cook and rely on snacking instead. There's nothing wrong with snacking, as long as you eat healthily (see box, right). Your nutrient intake will be fine if you can eat a good breakfast—oatmeal with berries or poached eggs on whole-wheat toast—have nutritional snacks throughout the day, and sit down to one simple main meal—perhaps a bowl of pasta (with sautéed shrimp, garlic, oil, and lemon juice) with steamed vegetables. As you find your rhythm, the time and energy to cook will return.

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Snacks and superfoods

Keep your snacks healthy and include plenty of "superfoods," such as blueberries, broccoli, tomatoes, oily fish, and oats. These give you much-needed vitamins, minerals, and antioxidants. Stock up on fresh fruit—especially bananas, which contain slow-release energy, and berries. Dried fruit, raw vegetables (carrots, broccoli, celery, etc.), cherry tomatoes, unsalted rice cakes, breadsticks, oatcakes, hummus, and guacamole are also great. Try making a tasty dip by blending cooked cannellini beans with olive oil and garlic in your food processor. Store it in the fridge, and eat with vegetable sticks or spread on oatcakes.



Finger food Easy to reach for and to eat with one hand, nutrient-rich snacks are ideal in the early days of taking care of your baby.

Sit down to eat your meals; eating on the run contributes to fatigue and can lead to overeating. If your baby wants to be held, put her in an infant sling so you are hands-free to eat.

Q I want to lose my baby weight. Is it okay to start dieting now?

Dieting too soon after the birth can delay your recovery and sap your energy levels, but if you eat sensibly and healthily, you will gradually lose your baby weight. You will find that you shed some weight fairly quickly after the birth as you lose "extras" such as the amniotic fluid and any water retention. Now that you are taking care of a baby, you should find yourself more active than in the last stages of pregnancy

and will be burning off more energy. However, it's recommended that you wait until you have had your six-week checkup before you start watching your calorie intake if you are not breast-feeding, and even then the advice is that you must not go on a crash diet. If you eat healthy, nutrient-rich foods in sensible amounts and exercise moderately every day so you lose fat and not muscle, you will gradually lose the weight and keep it off. Breast-feeding requires extra calories, so it's vital that you don't even think about restricting your calorie intake until after you have weaned your baby.